

PROJECT APPROVAL

Approving is not agreeing, it is interrogating.

The eight questions before saying yes to a project.

AND THE CONSEQUENCE

The project nobody interrogated in the room is the one
that stalls six months later.

THE CASCADE

The room debates the solution and nobody interrogates the problem.

WHAT YOU SEE

Someone presents a finished solution, well designed, with a timeline and a team.

THE MECHANISM

The conversation goes straight to the how, and the why stays assumed.

THE CONSEQUENCE

Whoever doubts looks like the contrarian, so the doubt dies before becoming a question.

The proposal enters the roadmap with the first question still unanswered.

THE FORK

What kind of question does your room usually ask?

WHICH QUESTIONS

01

Does the question ask for a defense?

why do you think it will work, the answer comes as rhetoric

02

Does the question ask for detail?

how many people, what timeline, the answer comes as a plan

03

Does the question ask for evidence?

how will we know it worked, the answer comes as criteria

A question that asks for a defense rewards whoever speaks best.
One that asks for evidence rewards whoever thought first.

THE METHOD

The Grilling, four gates.



01 THE PROBLEM

are we solving the right problem, and attacking the cause

02 THE PATH

is there a simpler alternative, and what has to exist first

03 THE PRICE

who will be affected, and which risks we accept taking now

04 THE PROOF

how will we know it worked, and what we do if we are wrong

Fail one gate and you go back to the first. There is no skipping ahead to the next.

WHAT TO ASK, IN ORDER

The eight questions, in order.

01 • THE PROBLEM

Are we solving the right problem?

02 • THE PROBLEM

Are we attacking the cause?

03 • THE PATH

Is there a simpler alternative?

04 • THE PATH

What has to exist first?

05 • THE PRICE

Who will be affected?

06 • THE PRICE

Which risks do we accept?

07 • THE PROOF

How will we know it worked?

08 • THE PROOF

What happens if we are wrong?

TWO MODELS

Two ways to approve a project.

THE COMMON MODEL

The approving committee

Starts with the solution presented

Debates timeline, cost and team

Approves whoever defends it best

Finds the error during execution

THE DESIGNED MODEL

The grilling

Starts with the stated problem

Debates cause, alternative and proof

Approves whoever answers with criteria

Finds the error while still in the room

MISTAKE AND CONSEQUENCE

The cost of skipping each gate.

01 Skipping the problem.

→ six months of a team treating a symptom.

02 Skipping the path.

→ twelve months of project where three weeks would do.

03 Skipping the price.

→ the affected team finds out at launch and blocks it.

04 Skipping the proof.

→ nobody can say if it worked, and it becomes folklore.

The fourth is the dearest. With no agreed proof, the result is interpretation.

THE CHAIN

The slide one test.

01 Open the proposal document and read only the first sentence.



02 If it describes the solution, the problem was never defined.



03 If it describes the problem, the grilling can begin.



WHERE LEADERSHIP STEPS IN

Five seconds of reading prevent six months of execution against the wrong target.

RUN IT THIS WAY NEXT TIME

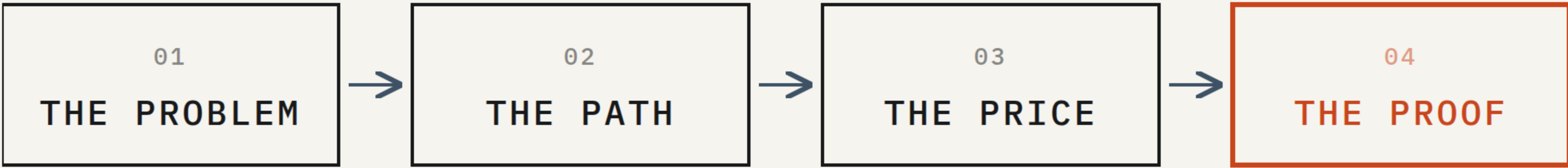
Three moves at the next approval.

		
STEP 01	STEP 02	STEP 03
Send the eight questions before the meeting.	Always start at the problem gate.	Record the answer to seven at the moment of approval.
whoever presents answers in writing, the room debates the answers	with no answer to one and two, nobody debates the solution	the success criterion is born with the yes, never afterward

Start with the most expensive project in your queue. That is where question eight hurts most and saves most.

THE MODEL THAT STICKS

The Grilling, in the order that matters.



A project that does not survive eight questions in the room does not survive six months of execution.

SAVE THIS FOR LATER

on the next proposal that reaches you for approval.

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